A corollary to this was the idea that Islam contains an inherent colonizing imperative and, thus, that Muslims seek to expand and overtake other religions. Some narrators explained this as the meaning of Jihad and Sharia, two words we often heard to be used, though not necessarily well understood. Arguments about the intrinsically dangerous nature of Islam are timeless in their universality, but in some cases narrators situated their arguments temporally, pointing to countries including Afghanistan and Indonesia, which were understood to have once been Buddhist and then lost to Islam. Narrators stated that Buddhism in Myanmar is at similar risk of being "swallowed up". A variety of mechanisms were presented to explain how this could occur, including: use of violence, economic power, and demographic change driven by practices imputed to Muslims — illegal immigration, bearing large numbers of children, incentives for inter-religious marriage, and forced conversion of Buddhist women and subsequent children.

A consideration of the spatial aspects of these arguments further highlights their universality, couched in terms of religion. Claims about Islam were illustrated through three strands of interrelated argument, which can be understood as global, through reference to international events; local or national, through reference to events within Myanmar; and personal, through reference to the experiences of the narrator. The following excerpt from an interview in Lashio, for example, illustrates a synthesis of these three strands of argument:

> The things that happened took place not far from our work place — members of the other religion rape children like your daughter's age, and we read about that in the news and also see it in real life … Their religion is terrorism. They lured people to convert to their religion by force; they don't have freedom of belief in their religion. If a Burmese Buddhist got married to one of them, every opportunity would be lost. Even a drop of blood from them is very dangerous. The blood of terror. They have been taught this since they were children, so it's very terrifying. We say, don't kill. … They say, kill — if you kill you will be blessed. … Now, in the news, we see about their Jihad in other countries, cutting off people's heads. Horrible things, burning people alive. … I don't want to see our Buddhists suffer like that. That's why I want to show people the horror of their religion. I want everyone to know.[12]

My colleague and I conducted this interview with a woman who works at the central office of the Shan State MaBaTha and so it is not surprising she was a particularly illustrative narrator. She spoke to us earnestly, sometimes